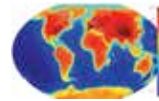




Tech of Tomorrow

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form and technique to improve efficiency as well as keep career ending injuries at bay. The latter is an unavoidable hazard in competitive sports where the human body is stretched to the absolute limit. Nursing injuries that put sportsmen away for prolonged periods lead to millions lost in the lucrative world of sports.

The answer to this dilemma of pushing the body's limits and exposing athletes to injury is answered through hyperbaric oxygen chambers. Originally devised as a means to treat burn victims, drivers suffering from the bends, and smoke inhalation injuries, these chambers are known to remarkably expedite the body's natural healing process. This is achieved by delivering a highly concentrated dosage of oxygen in an airtight chamber maintained at a relatively high pressure. The oxygen rich environment helps with inflammation and increases synthesis and the efficiency of epithelial and red blood cells to aid recovery.

Sportsmen plagued with injuries have found this emerging new healthcare technology a godsend for quick recovery.



Hyperbaric oxygen therapy provides rapid recovery from athletic injuries

Star players such as David Beckham and Lance Armstrong have been known to take hyperbaric oxygen chamber therapy to recover from serious injuries at a much quicker pace demanded by their crazy practice and tournament schedules. It isn't just about injury treatment. Specialised muscle compression machines are in high demand with athletes engaged sports involving high cardiovascular stress such as swimming, running, and

cycling. The performance of athletes in these routines is severely limited by the onset of muscle stress, which is characterised by the generation of lactic acid within the muscles. These compression machines are employed by cyclists in between stages for quicker and better muscle recovery before the next event. Swimmers, runners, and other athletes competing in track and field events are also benefiting from their game changing rejuvenating effects.

Programming the Mind

So far we have established that at the highest echelons of athletic excellence, sportsmen transcend the very human failings of willpower, effort, and capability to reach a sort of performance parity that distills superiority down to genetic predisposition. We have seen these athletes try and break the performance parity with drugs, biomechanical enhancements, and other advancements taking care of physiological damage and stress involved with athletic training. With the body transformed into a powerhouse of performance through the wonders of science and technology, the final frontier for improvement happens to be the mind itself.

Interestingly, efforts are already being done to take the quintessentially unpredictability of the human mind out of the equation. We know this phenomenon as sports psychology where, under all the smoke and mirrors, the basic idea is to transform a naturally anxious and fearful psyche into a goal-oriented tool working towards the singular objective of achieving excellence. The fear of failure, performance anxiety are essentially endocrinal chemical secretions that can have a profound bearing on athletic success. Like they say – games are won and lost in the mind.

Athletes are taking the final step towards their transformation into a machine-like pursuit for excellence

by conditioning their very minds. The existence of the field of sports hypnosis is proof. The fields of sports psychology and hypnosis are akin to programming



Our heroes, after all, need to be distinctly human

a machine, or in this case, programming the mind to take away human fallibility out of the equation.

Down the Slippery Slope

In essence, all avenues of science, technology, and psychology are committed to imbuing athletes with an almost super-human machine-like mental and physical predisposition. The most logical next step would involve genetically engineered babies tailor-made to excel at certain sports. And if that's the slippery slope we plan to go down, what's stopping us from enhancing our test-tube sportsmen with cybernetic enhancements a la Warren Ellis' graphic novel Transmetropolitan.

Given the extent of dehumanisation, would this really be about human excellence? If we are going so far as to create genetically engineered super-athletes with cybernetic enhancements, why not just pit robots against each other?

Probably because the very spirit of sportsmanship and athletic excellence is the celebration of the victory of the human mind and soul over insurmountable odds. The victory over complacency, laziness, and a general lack of discipline that prevents most common men from achieving the greatness and sacrifice associated with an athlete. The last time we checked, human beings didn't look up to machines as their heroes and role models. Isn't that ironic? 